

Case Study: Pride Circle — Bringing 8,600+ LGBT+ Job Seekers to RISE Through Niche Meta Ads Targeting

At a glance

Meta stopped letting advertisers target the LGBT+ community directly. Working around that, I took Pride Circle's RISE job fair registrations from 37 in the first campaign to 5,713 across five for RISE 2024, and cut cost per lead from ₹729.73 to ₹58.08, a 92% drop. I returned in 2025 as a freelancer and brought in another 2,902 leads on ₹1,50,000, taking the total to 8,615 leads at a blended ₹58.85 each.

Metric	Campaign 1 (Nov)	Campaign 5 (Mar)
New registrations	37	2,066
Cost per lead	₹729.73	₹58.08 (−92%)
Best campaign		Campaign 4: 2,405 registrations at ₹49.90
Total registrations		5,713
Budget used		₹3,57,000 of ₹4,50,000
Blended cost per lead		₹62.49

- **Client:** Pride Circle, an organisation building LGBT+ inclusion in workplaces and campuses
- **Event:** RISE 2024 and RISE 2025, an LGBT+ exclusive job fair connecting skilled professionals with inclusive employers
- **My role:** Performance marketing on Facebook and Instagram: audience strategy, creative testing, budget allocation and reporting
- **Duration:** 5 months of campaigns, one per month from November to March

The challenge

RISE needed two things: eligible candidates from the LGBT+ community to register and get hired by inclusive employers, and awareness that such a fair existed at all. Many in the community don't see traditional marketing channels, so Meta was the natural place to reach them.

The obstacle was targeting. Meta no longer allows advertisers to target the LGBT+ community directly, so there was no "LGBT+" box to tick. I had to reach people through their interests, behaviours and the places they go, and keep lead quality high, since the fair was for candidates with real work experience. The goal was cost-efficient registrations for the job fair website, with ₹4,50,000 allotted.

Campaign 1 (November): Proving the targeting

I started with one audience: men interested in men, using partner-preference and romantic interests as a stand-in for direct targeting. I limited delivery to Tier 1 and Tier 2 cities, where the experienced candidates the employers wanted were concentrated, and used single static creatives.

Result: 37 registrations at ₹729.73 each on ₹27,000. It was expensive, but every registrant was from the intended community. That told me the proxy targeting worked, and the audience could be widened with confidence.

Campaign 2 (December): Adding a second audience

I added a second ad set for women interested in women and split the budget evenly between the two. I also moved from single statics to carousels.

Result: Registrations rose from 37 to 51 and cost per lead fell from ₹729.73 to ₹588.24. Reach nearly doubled, from 12,789 to 24,697, and 22 of the 51 registrations came from women. Broadening the audience helped on both volume and cost, but the numbers were still too small and too expensive.

Campaign 3 (January): The breakthrough

This was the turning point. I built custom audiences from Pride Circle's own Facebook, Instagram and website audiences, then created 1% and 2% lookalike audiences from them for both ad sets. I widened the age range from 23-45 to 22-48, doubled the daily budget to ₹1,000 per ad set, and switched to "quantitative" creatives, which led with concrete numbers about the fair in statics and carousels.

Result: Registrations jumped from 51 to 1,154 on ₹60,000. Reach grew from 24,697 to 87,316, and cost per lead dropped from ₹588.24 to ₹51.99, a 91% fall. Pride Circle's existing audience was the best signal Meta could have, and it did what interest targeting alone couldn't.

Campaign 4 (February): Scaling, and a mistake worth learning from

I added a 5% lookalike audience to push reach to 1,44,053 people, raised spend to ₹2,000 per ad set per day, and introduced reels made in-house and by influencers.

Result: Registrations rose to 2,405 at ₹49.90, the lowest cost per lead of the project. But the quality of registrations fell. The 5% lookalike audience was too loose and pulled in people who matched Pride Circle's audience on paper but not the fair's candidate profile. A cheap lead that doesn't fit the employers is not worth much, so I made a conscious decision to go back to 1% and 2% lookalikes while keeping reels.

Campaign 5 (March): Quality and inclusion

I dropped the 5% lookalike, returned to 1% and 2%, and added location targeting around nine NGOs working with transgender individuals, so the fair's registrations reflected the full community rather than mostly gay men and lesbian women. A Hindi reel by LGBT+ influencer Lalit, explaining the fair in relatable language, carried the campaign.

Result: 2,066 registrations at ₹58.08 on ₹1,20,000. Registrations were lower than Campaign 4 and cost per lead rose by ₹8.18, but the leads were better and more diverse. This was the second-highest volume of the five campaigns, with tighter targeting.

Results across all five campaigns

	Nov	Dec	Jan	Feb	Mar
New registrations	37	51	1,154	2,405	2,066
Budget used	₹27,000	₹30,000	₹60,000	₹1,20,000	₹1,20,000
Cost per lead	₹729.73	₹588.24	₹51.99	₹49.90	₹58.08
Days run	27	30	30	30	30

- **5,713 total registrations** on ₹3,57,000 of the ₹4,50,000 budget, a blended cost per lead of ₹62.49.
- **₹93,000 left unspent**, returned to the client unused.
- **Cost per lead down 92%** from the first campaign to the last.

RISE 2025: Back as a freelancer

I came back to RISE in 2025 as a freelancer, running the Meta Ads while studying at Warwick.

Result: 2,902 LGBT+ leads over 5 months on a budget of ₹1,50,000, a cost per lead of about ₹51.69. That is roughly 17% lower than the blended ₹62.49 from RISE 2024.

	RISE 2024	RISE 2025	Combined
Leads	5,713	2,902	8,615
Spend	₹3,57,000	₹1,50,000	₹5,07,000
Cost per lead	₹62.49	₹51.69	₹58.85
Duration	5 months	5 months	

Key learnings

1. **When you can't target a community directly, start narrow and prove it.** One audience at a time showed which proxies delivered the right people before I spent at scale.
2. **Your own audience is the strongest targeting asset.** Custom and 1-2% lookalike audiences cut cost per lead by 91% in a single campaign.
3. **Cheapest isn't best.** The 5% lookalike produced the lowest cost per lead and the weakest leads. I reverted to protect quality and accepted a slightly higher cost.
4. **Match creative to the audience.** Hindi reels from a community influencer carried Campaign 5 even with tighter targeting, because they felt relatable rather than corporate.
5. **Targeting can widen who you reach, not just how many.** NGO location targeting brought transgender candidates into the fair.
6. **Test the call to action.** "Apply Now" outperformed the alternatives for RISE.
7. **Scale budget behind what works.** Daily spend rose from ₹500 to ₹2,000 per ad set only as results justified it.